Mindful prostration

Three prostrations, made slowly, with every movement noted. The practice that opens a session.

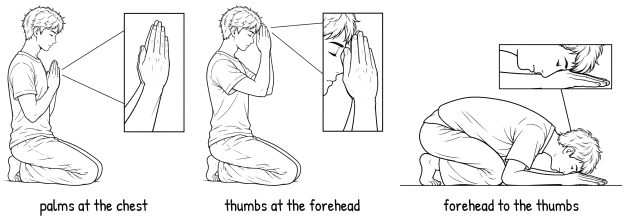
1 · BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Kneel down. Either tuck the toes under and sit back on the heels, or rest the tops of the feet on the floor and sit on them, whichever is comfortable enough to keep still in. Rest the hands palm down on the thighs, keep the back straight, and leave the eyes open throughout.



Both kneeling positions are correct. Choose the one your knees and ankles allow.

Each movement gets one word, said silently three times, once as it begins, once in the middle, once as it ends. A hand rising is noted *raising, raising, raising*, timed to the movement itself. Move slowly enough that this is possible.



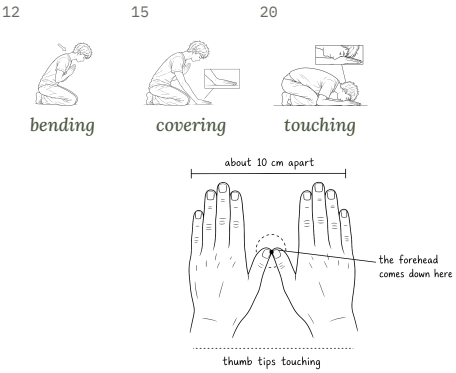
Palms at the chest, thumbs at the forehead, forehead to the thumbs.

2 · GOING DOWN

From kneeling, hands on the thighs: turn the right hand a quarter turn until it is upright, noting *turning*, then raise it toward the chest, noting *raising*, until the thumb touches, noting *touching*. Do the same with the left hand, so the palms meet with both thumbs at the chest. Raise both hands to the forehead, noting *raising*, until the thumbnails touch, noting *touching*, then lower them back to the chest.



Bend the back forward to about forty five degrees, noting *bending*. Lower the right hand to the floor in front of the knees, held upright, noting *lowering*, until the edge of the little finger touches, noting *touching*, then turn it flat, palm down, noting *covering*. Do the same with the left hand beside it. Bend forward further, bringing the forehead down to the thumbs, noting *bending* then *touching*. This completes one prostration.



Thumb tips touching, about 10cm apart. The forehead comes down onto the thumbs, not the floor between them.

3 · COMING UP, AND THE NEXT PROSTRATION

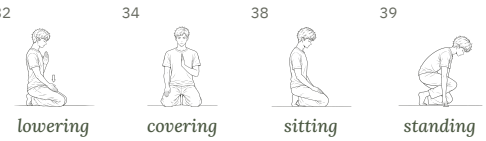
Raise the back until the arms are straight, noting *raising*. Turn the right hand up onto its edge, noting *turning*, and raise it from the floor to the chest, noting *raising* then *touching*. Do the same with the left hand, straightening the back upright as you do, so the palms meet at the chest. Raise both hands to the forehead, then lower them to the chest, the same as before.



From here, return to **Going down** and prostrate again, so there are three prostrations in all.

4 · FINISHING

After the third prostration, come up through the forehead and chest as above, then lower the hands back to the thighs one at a time, right then left, noting *lowering*, *touching*, *covering*. Rest a moment, aware of sitting, noting *sitting* twice, then come up to standing, noting *standing* twice. Go straight into walking meditation from here, without breaking the awareness in between. The point of finishing carefully is that there is no gap for the mind to slip through.



Thoughts, aches and impatience arise here as they do anywhere else. If something interrupts, pause the sequence, note what is present until it fades, then pick it up where you left it, rather than hurrying to the end of a prostration in order to deal with it afterwards.

On speed. Three prostrations done this way take several minutes. If you find yourself moving smoothly and quickly through the sequence, the practice has turned into a routine and the noting has stopped doing any work. Slow down until each movement has to be attended to again.

THE NOTES

sitting

turning

raising

touching

lowering

bending

covering

raising

standing

These instructions follow the meditation manual of Yuttadhammo Bhikkhu. The technique is the style of insight practice as taught by Ajahn Tong Sirimangalo, in which experience is noted silently and in plain language as it occurs. The numbered step drawings are by the team at sirimangalo.org and are used with their permission.